The most successful of all these conquests was of the Mughal Empire that lasted from 1528 till 1858. Beginning with the rule of emperor Babur (whose grave, *Bagh-e-Babur*, is in Kabul), the Mughal Empire included great rulers such as Akbar, Shahjahan, and the controversial Aurangzeb, all of who play an important role in contemporary India's historical imagination.[11]

No other entity underlines the depth of India and Afghanistan's historical and geographical proximity more than the Grand Trunk Road (GTR). One of Asia's oldest and longest roads connecting Chittagong with Kabul via Delhi and Lahore, the origins of the GTR date back to the Mauryan era, even though its modern version was built in the sixteenth century by Sher Shah Suri, an ethnic Pashtun, who took over control of the Mughal Empire in 1540, with its capital in Delhi.[12] Of tremendous commercial and military value, the road knit together the countries and cultures of this region. Mughal rule, however, came to an end after the failed Indian rebellion of 1857 (Delhi, the seat of the Mughal Empire was under Bahadur Shah Zafar's rule) that led to the formal institution of the British Monarchy, or the British Raj, in 1858. The East India Company (EIC), that developed influence in South Asian politics decades before the 1857 uprising, gave Britain authority over parts of South Asia. British colonial policies towards Afghanistan over the next two centuries formed a critical historical and structural basis for contemporary South Asian and Afghan politics.

A quest for logical territorial limits of the Indian empire steered British diplomatic, political and military activity towards Afghanistan.[13] Reasons for this were as much related to defence from external threats as to exercising sovereignty over a defined territory and people. Leading up to the three Anglo-Afghan wars (1839–42, 1878–80, 1919), such an interventionist approach developed Afghanistan as something of a 'buffer zone' between colonial India and Russia.[14] The Durand Line Agreement of 1893, signed between Britain and Amir Abdur Rahman Khan, was aimed at defining these territorial limits.[15] Where to draw the line and how to define the nature of British India's relationship with Afghanistan were hotly debated subjects. Resultantly, the so-called 'ring fence' concept of a dual-layered defence system for India, i.e. an inner ring and an outer ring, came to typify imperial security imagination in the subcontinent.[16] The idea was to develop an administered frontier, a non-administered frontier, and an external